

■ By Rohit Parihar

In Rajasthan, the complex social and economic stratum that is the basis for caste and community is inherently feudal—and inherently volatile. Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje knew that when she faced a serious agitation by the Gurjar community demanding Scheduled Tribe (ST) status to ensure reservations a year ago. She reacted as a politician then, making a slew of promises to convince the community, led by retired Colonel Kirori Singh Bainsla, to call off their mass protests. Now, even as she fulfilled these, the Gurjars realised they still did not have one thing they were interested in—the ST status—and the agitation has returned to haunt her and her administration. This time, it promises to be a bloodier confrontation with serious ramifications for law and order, not just



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THE CASTE SCOURGE THREATENS TO TURN INTO A SERIOUS LAW AND ORDER PROBLEM

in Rajasthan but neighbouring states as well and Raje has only herself to blame.

Last year, after the Gurjar leaders had called off their agitation, she was convinced by her officials and ministers that their manipulation of the talks had broken the back of the Gurjar movement and that Bainsla's authority had been

undermined. It was a fatal miscalculation. Not only did the Gurjars see through the fig leaf of sops she handed out, but it also made Bainsla more determined to prove that he was the sole voice of the community. Last year, when the violence peaked, the Government cleverly made scapegoats out of Prehlad Gunjal and Atar Singh